Brahmins, who explained the meaning of the texts orally to the Persian scholars in Hindi. ‘Several learned Brahmans—such as Deva Misra, Satabadhana, Madhusudan Misra, Chaturbhuja and Shaikh Bhavan, who embraced Islam because of the attention of his blessed Majesty,’ wrote Naqib Khan in his colophon to the translation, ‘read this book and explained it in Hindi to me, a poor wretched man, who wrote it in Persian.’ Badauni also claimed that Akbar spent several nights with the translators, explaining the meaning of the epic to the Persian scholars. Abu’l Fazl would later contribute a preface to the book and Faizi would rework two books from the epic into verse. The *Razmnama*, or Book of War, would be gorgeously illustrated and the imperial master copy ‘numbers among the finest, most highly valued specimens of Mughal art that survive today’ according to Truschke. The paintings were altogether different from the earlier styles of the Timurid, Safavid, or Sultanate traditions that the artists came from as the work itself was that disconcerting entity—a singularity that had never been imagined before. Once it was completed, ‘the Amirs had orders to take copies of it, with the blessing and favour of God’, implying that Akbar wished for the Persian translation of the Mahabharat to be circulated widely.

The translation of the *Razmnama* was begun in 1582 and took about eighteen months to complete. After that began the process of copying the text in beautiful calligraphy, and of illustrating the manuscript. The final manuscript, divided into four large volumes, and containing 168 illustrations, was completed around 1586–87. The illustrations were necessarily collaborative efforts, given the large number of paintings and the detailed nature of the illustrations, and the main artists were Basawan, Lal, and Daswant. These three artists between them designed and outlined most of the illustrations, while artists like Muhammad Sharif and Farrukh Beg contributed to some of the paintings. Interestingly, thirteen of the paintings are horizontal compositions, unique among Mughal manuscripts but current in traditional Hindu religious texts. Unfortunately, the paintings of the imperial *Razmnama*, and the manuscript itself, have been off-limits to scholars and enthusiasts alike as they have remained sealed in the City Palace Museum in Jaipur by court order for more than half a century.*

Not everyone was equally enamoured of these intellectual exercises. Mullah Shari and Haji Thanesari loathed having to work on the translations, considering it an attempt to denigrate Islam. As for Badauni, writing about